



Microsoft revamps Hotmail

Software giant Microsoft has just revamped its email service Hotmail to which has Metro interface design

Hidden dangers of Facebook

Being a Facebook addict or posting unnecessary information would be critically dangerous.

<http://digit.in/LVwsfI>

Motherboard test

board. It provides a mini PCIe header beside the ROG Connect button on which you can attach the mPCIe combo card which can house either an mSATA SSD or a WiFi card.

The other ASUS board is your mainstream P8Z77-V whose main feature is the on-board WiFi connectivity. It offers WiFi adapter which allows you to set up a WiFi hotspot, control your system with a smartphone or tablet, do DLNA streaming as well as file transfers between your PC and smartphone/tablet. Fan Xpert 2 is another good utility which allows you to control each of the fans connected to your board. Overclocking on both the ASUS boards is quite easy from the UEFI BIOS, which also has a shortcut key-F3, to pull up the most used controls and tweak them. The Ai Suite II is a wonderful utility to overclock ASUS boards from the OS environment. We easily went over 4.4GHz on both the boards on air, giving a 20 per cent boost in CineBench R11.5.

Winner

This category had a close fight between the last four boards, but ASUS Maximus V Gene emerged as the overall Best Buy thanks to its supreme score in three out of the four main aspects of the testing. MSI Z77A-GD55 was another very good board we found in this segment with a cheaper price than the Maximus V Gene, but the feature packed Gene board edged past it.

OVER ₹17,000

This segment had six boards featuring three from ASUS and one each from Gigabyte, ECS and MSI. Starting with the most expensive of the lot – the gold and black coloured ECS Z77H2-

AX. It has 15 micron gold contact on the CPU socket, PCIe slots and memory slots which assist in conduction of current. Has onboard WiFi and Bluetooth and extra PLX chip for more PCIe lanes. The BIOS despite being a UEFI one, does not assist one much when it comes to overclocking, specially when one compares it with BIOSes from ASUS, MSI or Gigabyte. Also the overclocking utility bundled wasn't as great as the ones offered by competing vendors. The eOC utility does not have multiplier option. There is a lot of scope for improvement on this front. It has a great build quality on the VRM heatsink and the southbridge heatsink has a temperature sensitive sticker. Placement of SATA ports is good.

ASUS had three boards namely the P8Z77V PRO, P8Z77 V DELUXE and Sabertooth Z77. The board that is interesting is the Sabertooth Z77 which comes covered with the Thermal Armour. It helps to direct the hot air away from the motherboard and its components. You can add in the extra fans provided which draw in cold air and drive away the hot air. Convection holes under the motherboard further help in dissipating heat. The Thermal Radar utility helps you monitor temperatures at multiple points on the board which are fitted with sensors. It does not have dedicated power/reset buttons, voltage check points, on-board WiFi, etc. Both the P8Z77 V Pro and P8Z77 V Deluxe sport on-board WiFi along with the EPU and TPU goodness. The ASUS boards have the most user-friendly UEFI BIOSes making overclocking a piece of cake. We easily overclocked to 4.5GHz on all ASUS boards over air. Ai Suite II is an all-in-one utility to monitor your temper-

atures, voltages and power. You can also over-clock from the utility itself.

Gigabyte Z77X-UD5H is the flagship board from Gigabyte's Z77 lineup barring the G1 Sniper series of gaming boards. So UD5H is packed to the gills with an exhaustive feature set including dedicated power/reset buttons, POST error code LED, sturdy heat-sinks, on-board voltage check points, on-board mSATA port, on-board WiFi among other things. The heat sinks are joined by a heat pipe which assists in dissipating heat. It comes with the 3D Power digital engine along with the 3D Power Utility to monitor and tweak voltage, phase and frequency. Overclocking using the BIOS is quite easy but you would be much better off not using them mouse as the Gigabyte BIOS responds very slowly to mouse movements or commands. The UD5H is one well rounded board.

The MSI Z77A-GD80 was the only board featuring the Intel Thunderbolt port amongst all the boards tested. MSI is one of the first in that aspect making the board future proof. The Thunderbolt cable is capable of reaching theoretical speeds of upto 10 Gbps and can deliver data from the PCI express and display port. PCIe as well as display port signals enter the Thunderbolt cable separately. The entry point Thunderbolt controller (which is present on either end of the cable) multiplexes these signals and passes them through the cable, which



MSI Z77A-GD80

is then demultiplexed by the exit point Thunderbolt controller. Apart from the Thunderbolt goodness, the GD80 features all the military grade components, has all the other features such present on the GD55 and better heatsinks. It has an onboard OC Genie button as well as voltage check points. All in all a sturdy future proof board.

Winner

Although we had some very interesting boards in this segment such as the ASUS Sabertooth Z77, MSI Z77A-GD80 and Gigabyte Z77X-UD5H, selecting the best value for money board was a difficult task. However, keeping in mind the scores across the four testing sections, and the price, we had a clear winner in Gigabyte Z77X-UD5H. Having said that, the ASUS Sabertooth Z77 is also a good board, but loses out on some crucial features. MSI Z77A-GD80 was awarded the Editor's Pick as it had most of the features present on the UD5H and Sabertooth Z77, but it had one forward looking feature in the form of Thunderbolt port. You will have to invest money in a thunderbolt cable though. Price proposition was better than ASUS P8Z77 V Deluxe. **d**